

institutions to provide 27 per cent quota for OBCs.

As far as the ministry is concerned, it's simple. Since it funds 100 per cent of the IITs, the ministry is bound to flex its muscles. The IITs, it claims, are perfectly free to raise their incomes through fee hike, research and development, faculty consultations or alumni endowment. It's how the IITs have learnt to be self-sufficient. Since 2003, IIM-Ahmedabad, Bangalore and Kolkata, which received grants of around Rs 10 crore a year, have not taken any grant from the Government, relying increasingly on in-house training and consultancy programmes. Take IIM-A, which made Rs 25 crore through training and consultancy programmes in 2008. Yet, says Bakul Dholakia, who was director of IIM-A at the height of its confrontation with Joshi, they were not given the freedom to decide faculty compensation. In March 2005, IIM-A prepared a paper on autonomy and accountability and submitted it to the ministry. Later, the R.C. Bhargava Committee was appointed by the Government to study the issue, but both gathered dust. "What is the incentive to perform then?" he says.

It's not that IITs do not earn from other sources. For example, last year, IIT-Kanpur earned Rs 80 crore from various sponsored research and consultancy projects. But they are more expensive to run. If an average IIM budget is Rs 10-15 crore annually, an average IIT's budget is over 10 times that. The reason is that the IITs need to spend on research and development and maintaining laboratories. Also their fee per year is lower compared to the IIMs—while IIMs charge Rs 6 lakh a year for the post graduate programme, IITs charge Rs 50,000 a year for an undergraduate degree. But the seven IITs, on which the ministry spends Rs 120-180 crore each on grants, often struggle to pay even salaries. In 2006-07, 63 per cent of IIT-Kharagpur's donation (Rs 5.4

Standoff with Sibal After M.M. Joshi and Arjun Singh, it's the hyperactive minister's turn to fall foul of the IITs

HRD Ministry's Diktat

The ministry wants only four out of every 10 professors to be eligible for a higher salary after six years.

The ministry wants fresh PhDs to be given contractual posts.

IITs and IIMs should hire as professors only those who have served as associate professors in recognised institutes.

Only PhDs with a minimum of three years work experience should be employed. The basic salary should be Rs 30,000, with an additional Rs 8,000.

IIT Faculty Demands

The faculty says all should be eligible.

Young PhDs are the IITs' lifeblood. IITs must continue to be able to recruit such scholars in permanent positions.

Such a restriction would prevent IITs from hiring the best in the field, regardless of their experience.

The pay scale for PhDs with experience should be higher.

crore) went towards faculty support. Last year, IIT-Bombay had written to the HRD Ministry saying it could not even pay its faculty their salaries. IIT-Kanpur too had to dip into its own corpus and extract around Rs 4 crore to set up an extension centre in Noida to conduct short term courses.

"The fight is for our autonomy, dignity and honour that the ministry is systematically robbing the IITs of."

M. THENMOZHI, *President, All-India-IIT Faculty Federation*



P.V. INDIRESAN.

Former Director, IIT-Madras

"A university should have three kinds of freedom: whom to teach, what to teach and who will teach."

Dholakia argues that the IITs are competing with corporates and international universities to recruit people with exposure and qualifications. "It's all right if you can't compete with corporates, but at least pay them the best within the teaching community." He adds, "You can't compare them with university teachers. That is what the faculty is up in arms against." Adds P.V. Indiresan, former IIT-Madras director, "A university should have three kinds of freedom: whom to teach, what to teach and who will teach. You cannot take away that from them."

The teaching community, however, is divided. Ashok Jhunjhunwala, professor at IIT-Madras, has written a letter to the faculty federation, saying there is a significant amount of autonomy, and the salary structure is in line with government compensation. With the directors of the institutes maintaining a hands-off stand, the battle is really between the faculty and Sibal, with neither seeming in a mood to compromise. Sibal says he will "walk a mile with them, if they walk two steps with me". Yes, but who will take the first step forward? ■